

THANKSGIVING 2026 - HOSTING PLAN

Thursday, November 26, 2026 | Rush household, Decatur

Florence visiting from Denver

Fritz cooking. Diane running the front of house. Florence contributing the pot roast recipe from her own Sunday tradition, plus her cranberry-orange relish.

GUEST LIST (8 adults, 2 kids)

- Fritz, Diane
- Carter (4), Ava (1)
- Florence (from Denver, arriving Nov 24)
- Rebecca Rush (Diane's sister)
- Grace Nelson (best friend, first Thanksgiving with us)
- Grace's partner Marcus
- Kevin and Kate Osborne (Kevin's first invite as mentor becoming friend)

TIMELINE

Nov 24 (Tuesday): Florence arrives ATL, Fritz picks her up in the CR-V. Settle her into the guest room (converted den for her stay). Quiet family dinner, no guests. Florence's first meal home: chicken and rice, per her request.

Nov 25 (Wednesday):

- 5:15 AM Fritz's greenway run (last long-ish run before the half-marathon peak)
- Morning: Diane at Gatewood remotely. Florence and Carter build the paper turkey

centerpiece.

- Afternoon: Fritz brines the turkey. 16-lb heritage bird from White Oak Pastures.
- 6:30 PM: Fritz leaves for choir rehearsal at Trinity, 7 PM start. Home by 9:15.
- Evening: Diane and Florence pre-portion the sides. Table set for 8.

Nov 26 (Thanksgiving):

- 5:15 AM Fritz's greenway run (short easy 3 miles, half-marathon taper)
- 6:00 AM: Chemex, single-origin Colombian, weekend ritual moved to Thursday
- 6:30 AM: Turkey out of brine, pat dry, in the roasting pan
- 7:00 AM: Turkey in the oven (325 degrees, 4 hours)
- 8:00 AM: Diane and Florence's coffee, Carter and Ava breakfast
- 9:00 AM: Sunday-substitute call to my mother is not needed - she's here!
- 10:00 AM: Sides prep begins. Kevin and Kate arrive early to help.
- 11:00 AM: Grace, Marcus, Rebecca arrive.
- 12:30 PM: Turkey rests. Sides finish.
- 1:00 PM: Dinner served.
- 3:00 PM: Kids' quiet time (Ava nap, Carter with the paper-turkey centerpiece).
- 4:00 PM: Coffee, dessert.
- 6:00 PM: Guests depart. Family cleanup with Rebecca staying overnight.

MENU

Bird:

- 16-lb heritage turkey, dry-brined Nov 25 morning through Nov 26 morning
- Herb butter under the skin (sage, rosemary, thyme from the patio pots before first frost took them)

- Roasted at 325 for 4 hours, tented after hour 2

Sides (Diane and Florence own):

- Mashed potatoes (Yukon Gold, butter, cream, salt) - Diane's
- Roasted Brussels sprouts with balsamic and pancetta - Fritz's
- Green bean casserole (Florence's version, no canned soup) - Florence's
- Cornbread stuffing with sausage and sage - Fritz's
- Roasted sweet potatoes with brown butter and pecans - Diane's
- Cranberry-orange relish (raw, no cooking) - Florence's recipe, Florence making it

Gravy:

- From turkey drippings and giblet stock, flour-thickened - Fritz's

Bread:

- Little Tart Bakeshop dinner rolls (Fritz picks up Nov 25 afternoon)

Dessert (Kate Osborne bringing):

- Pumpkin pie (Kate's grandmother's recipe)
- Pecan pie (store-bought from Buttermilk Sky, Kate insists on this one)
- Whipped cream, homemade

Kids:

- Ava: mashed sweet potato with butter, mashed banana. Turkey mashed and moistened.
- Carter: a bit of everything on his dinosaur plate. He'll eat the sweet potato and the mashed potato and the roll. Everything else is optimistic.

DRINKS

- Chemex coffee (Colombian) in the morning
- French press coffee at dessert (bigger volume)
- Two bottles of the Rioja from the Costco run
- Sparkling water for anyone driving
- Diet Coke for Grace (running joke about her not liking wine at holidays)

TABLE

Extended dining table plus the folding kids' table for Carter and Ava. Cloth napkins (the good ones from Diane's mother). Florence's centerpiece (Carter's paper turkey plus real gourds from the Decatur farmers market).

BOUNDARY REMINDERS

- Do not discuss the R21 review or the fortnight IDWeek trip during dinner.
Thanksgiving is a work-free zone.
- Do not discuss Florence's blood pressure or medication adherence at the table.
Handled quietly before or after.
- Grace does not know about the MTHFR variant or the postpartum thyroid history.
Keep as usual.
- Kevin knows my research context but not the family health context. Keep the separation.

FLORENCE LOGISTICS

- Guest room converted from the den. Bed made with the good sheets. Nightstand with water, tissues, and the Alexa alarm (she likes it for wake-up).
- She takes amlodipine in the morning with breakfast. Weekly blood pressure check I do quietly Sunday morning.
- She stays through Dec 22, returning to Denver Dec 22 morning. Her Christmas visit is a separate plan starting Dec 18 - overlap for the last few days of November stay flowing into her Christmas visit is a Denver-to-here trip that Fritz to book Amadeus for once the fortnight settles.

LEFTOVERS PLAN

- Turkey stock made Nov 27 morning from the carcass, batched for the freezer
- Pot pies made Nov 28 with turkey, gravy, and leftover vegetables
- Sandwiches Nov 27 for Rebecca to take home
- Florence gets a plate for Nov 27 (she likes leftovers more than fresh)